

KRISHNAPPA JAGANNATH
FARMER, KARNATAKA

Jagannath, a former gram panchayat president of Bellandur village near Bangalore, has turned social entrepreneur and ensured that his village adopts computers. He uses a laptop and has seen to it that villagers have access to government information and get land records.

a year and earn Rs 10 to 15 lakh each. Their crop yields are 30 per cent more than elsewhere in the region and its superior quality enables the farmers to find markets for it in Sangli, Maharashtra. Today, the value of farm produce of Anksapur is Rs 30 crore a year and the new prosperity is reflected in the better wages paid to farm labour. It has had a cascading effect on the development of infrastructure and utilities including the opening of two private English-medium schools.

That success story echoes in Fatehpura-Pilvai, in Gujarat's Mehsana district. The village has well-maintained cement homes and an impressive milk collection centre. The population is just over 1,000 but Fatehpura-Pilvai is way ahead of most of rural India when it comes to positive development and is a mirror

introduced drip irrigation techniques to reduce dependence on rains. Today half the 780 hectare farmland is under drip-irrigation-based horticulture cultivation with potatoes, pomegranate, papaya and vegetables being grown. The result has been a level of prosperity that no one here could have imagined. The village school has its own website and 16 computers are connected to the National Learning Programme.

Rural Land Boom The single biggest reason for the kind of money visible in rural India is the skyrocketing price of land. Bellandur's prosperity is partly to do with that. The local farmers sold chunks of their land to the office and housing complexes that dot the area as Bangalore's IT companies rapidly expand. Almost all villagers have come into sudden wealth from land sales. Gopala Reddy has just donated Rs 25 lakh to build a *gopura* in the village temple. His son drives around in a brand new SUV. Says Reddy: "We have sold our lands, made lots of money and our children have embraced technology or modern amenities and are in a different time and place from the past."

Another example is Ghata village near Gurgaon in Haryana. Om Prakash lives in a palatial house on a 300 sq mt plot in Ansal's upscale Sushant Lok. He presents an incongruous sight, sitting on a luxurious sofa set in his drawing room and smoking a hookah. He earned Rs 3.50 crore when he sold one acre of his land to a private builder just last year. The sharp jump in the income of villagers is reflecting in their living standards. Ford Endeavours rub bonnets with Skodas and Scorpions. Prakash still prefers home-cooked vegetarian food but his sons are non-vegetarians who chomp on burgers in Gurgaon malls where most of Ghata village boys hang out.

In neighbouring Punjab, Iqbal Singh's courtyard in Dhola village houses two buffaloes and a cow but there is a split AC in the living room where the family watches their huge, flat screen TV set. A shed once used for storing grain now houses a Scorpio and a Hyundai Accent. The family sold the 40 acres of land they owned to a tractor manufacturer. Each acre fetched them between Rs 60 lakh and Rs 1.50 crore. It's a story repeated all across Punjab. With big real estate companies entering Punjab, land prices have skyrocketed, tempting farmers to sell their land and live lives they had only seen in the movies or



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to the changing face of rural India. Almost every home has a television set and fridge, some boast of washing machines and air-conditioners as well. There are a dozen cars and nearly 150 two-wheelers and 40 tractors—unbelievable in a village which has just 200 homes. The heart of the village is the milk collection centre and it is normal to see girls wearing jeans and tracksuits carrying milk cans on their heads. The milk plant managed by the village milk cooperative society collects between 4,800 and 5,500 litres of milk every day which is sold in nearby towns. The society took a loan of Rs 13 lakh in 2006 and installed a bulk milk cooler plant so the milk does not go waste. The other source of revenue is agro-farming. After the 2001 earthquake, the villagers switched to horticulture and